Capturing expletive negation with complex left branches:

A cross-linguistic perspective

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Abstract

In this paper, we examine the cross-linguistic syncretisms between markers of negation and 'expletive negation' (ExN), i.e., a formal instance of negation lacking negative meaning, in *fear*-clauses. We argue that these syncretisms reflect structural proximity to the negative functional sequence (cf. De Clercq (2020) and Baunaz & Lander (2023)) and that ExN realises a high, epistemic modal feature (cf. Makri (2013) and Tsiakmakis & Espinal (2022) for Modern Greek). We then explain how the syncretisms can be captured in a uniform way. For this, we adopt the Nanosyntactic model of lexicalisation (cf. De Clercq et al. in press), and so-called stored 'complex left branches' (cf. De Clercq 2019). Ultimately, we show that, under the assumption that ExN is modal, all patterns can be accounted for by varying the shapes of lexical items, while keeping everything else equal.

Keywords: Expletive negation, fear-clauses, syncretism, Nanosyntax, complex left branches, epistemic modality

1 Introduction

Syncretism - the phenomenon whereby two distinct (morpho)syntactic categories are realised by the same marker - has proven to be a crucial tool in Nanosyntax (Starke 2009, De Clercq et al. in press) for uncovering the ordering of functional features across various empirical domains (cf. Caha 2009 on case, Pantcheva 2011 on directional expressions, Vanden Wyngaerd 2018 on pronouns, Baunaz (2015), Baunaz & Lander (2017), Baunaz & Lander (2021) on complementisers, Cortiula 2025 on verb classes, amongst many others). The domain that is central to the current discussion is negation.

Seminal work on this topic in Nanosyntax was carried out by De Clercq (2020). Building on Horn (2001)'s notions of predicate denial, predicate negation, and predicate term negation (going back to Aristotle), she argued that 'standard' or declarative negation does not correspond to a single, monolithic projection, but rather to a more fine-grained sequence of features - T, FOC, CLASS and Q respectively. Note that each of these features is negative and is characterised by its function in the clause and its scopal properties. For instance, T expresses sentential negation and takes scope over a TP, FOC expresses focus negation and takes scope over a particular constituent, and so on. Drawing on the patterns of syncretism exhibited by the negative markers in a sample of more than 24 languages, De Clercq further showed that these features are systematically ordered. A selection of the patterns is shown in Table 1.

	T	Foc	Class	Q
Modern Greek	dhen	oxi	mi	a-
Moroccan Arabic	ma(ši)	muši	muši	muši
Formal English	not	not	non-	un-
Hungarian	nem	nem	nem	-tElEn
Malagasy	tsy	tsy	tsy	tsy

Table 1: Syncretisms of standard negative markers

While some languages, such as Modern Greek, have dedicated markers for each type of negation, others, like Moroccan Arabic, English, Hungarian, and Malagasy, display varying degrees of syncretism across the same paradigm (as indicated by the grey cells). Importantly, however, what De Clercq observed is that syncretism only seems to target contiguous cells, meaning that the same markers are never used to realise, for instance, T and CLASS, or FOC and Q. Taking this observation as an indication of structural adjacency, in accordance with the *ABA-restriction (cf. Bobaljik 2012), she argued that the hierarchical ordering T > FOC > CLASS > Q is the only viable option. She refers to this ordering as the negative functional sequence (FSEQ).

Following De Clercq's work, Baunaz & Lander (2023) broadened the empirical scope to include markers of modal negation as well, specifically those expressing prohibition, negative volition, negative counterfactual conditionals, and negative possibility conditionals. Using a similar approach as De Clercq, they analysed the patterns of syncretism exhibited by a number of unrelated languages (see Table 2). Finding support especially in the presence of four distinct markers in Romeyka Greek, they proposed a decomposition of modal negation into the following features: PROH - VOL - CC - PC. These features are again distinguished by their functions and scope, and they are assumed to be situated above the ones of the base negative FSEQ. This is suggested by the morphological overlap between PC and T-negators in languages like Albanian, Modern Greek, Vietnamese, Hungarian and Mandarin Chinese.

	PROH	VOL	CC	PC	T	...
Romeyka Greek	mi	xe	mutš	midhen	u(tš)(i)	...
Albanian	mos	mos	mos	nuk	nuk/s'	...
Modern Greek	min	min	dhen	dhen	dhen	...
Vietnamese	đừng	không	không	không	không	...
Hungarian	ne	ne	nem	nem	nem	...
Latin	nē	nē	ni	nōn	nōn	...
Mandarin	biè	bù	bù	bù	bù	...

Table 2: Syncretisms of modal negative markers

Here too, there is considerable variation in how each language realises the different types of negation. Crucially, however, the same generalisation holds as for standard negation: if there is syncretism between two or more markers, it only occurs in contiguous cells. On the basis of the patterns in their sample, Baunaz & Lander (2023) then argued that the modal features must be hierarchically ordered as follows: PROH > VOL > CC > PC.

Against this background, the puzzle that we address in this paper concerns so-called 'expletive negation' (ExN), i.e., a formal instance of negation that does not seem to affect the polarity of the proposition it belongs to. We focus, in particular, on instances of ExN in *fear*-clauses. An example from Czech is given in (1).

(1) (Czech, Dočekal 2012)

a. Karel **ne**-přišel na oslavu.
   Karel NEG-came.PAST to party
   'Karel didn't come to the party.' (NEG)

b. Petr se bál, a-by Karel **ne**-přišel.
   Peter REFL feared that-SBJV Karel EXN-came.PAST
   'Peter was afraid that Karel would come.' (ExN)

The sentence in (1a) showcases the regular use of the Czech prefix *ne*- as a standard sentential negator, reversing the truth conditions of the proposition. In contrast, while *ne*- also appears in the sentence in (1b), it does not seem to contribute negative meaning. Despite its (obligatory) presence, the *fear*-clause is interpreted positively: Peter was afraid that Karel *would* come, not that he would not.[1] Due to this apparent lack of semantic contribution, ExN markers have often been described as semantically vacuous elements - or, at least, as elements devoid of negative force, whether inherently or as a result of syntactic or semantic operations (cf. Espinal 1992, 2000, Brown & Franks 1995, Abels 2005 amongst others).

Interestingly, however, the ExN marker in (1b) shares the same form with the real negator in (1a). This morphological overlap appears to be rather consistent cross-linguistically, but there is some flexibility regarding which negator ExN corresponds to. That is, in the context

[1] In many languages, amongst which Czech, the subjunctive plays a role in the interpretation. In (1), for instance, the replacement of *aby* ('that-SBJV)' with the indicative complementiser *že* ('that') would turn the clause into a negative one. While a full discussion on the interaction between ExN and the choice of mood is beyond the scope of this paper, we will note that arguments have been made against (cf. Makri 2013) and in favour of the subjunctive licensing ExN (cf. Tsiakmakis & Espinal 2022).

of *fear*-predicates, it seems that languages fall into one of three categories: those where ExN is identical to both the standard negative marker (glossed as NEG1) and the modal one (glossed as NEG2), those where it is identical to the modal negative marker only, and those where it matches a part of a bipartite negator - arguably the non-negative part.[2] These patterns are illustrated in Table 3, with Czech, Modern Greek and French serving as representative languages for each of them (see Section 2 for a more elaborate discussion of the data).[3]

	ExN	NEG2	NEG1
Czech	ne	ne	ne
Modern Greek	min	min	dhen
French	ne	ne pas	ne pas

Table 3: Patterns of syncretism between ExN and NEG

The recurrence of these cross-linguistic patterns suggests that the morphological identity between ExN and real negation is not merely accidental, but likely points to a systematic pattern of syncretism. However, if this line of reasoning is on the right track, and if we accept the earlier premise that syncretism signals structural proximity or even adjacency of morphosyntactic layers, we are faced with a formal chal-

[2]For the claim that bipartite negation consists of a negative and a non-negative marker, we follow Rowlett (1998) and De Clercq (2020) amongst others. As an anonymous reviewer pointed out, however, this is not a given in that both parts could also be considered negative. In this view, though, additional mechanisms are necessary to account for negative concord, e.g. factorisation or resumption (cf. Haegeman & Zanuttini 1991, Haegeman 1995, de Swart & Sag 2002).

[3]When we speak of 'French' in this paper, we are referring to what De Clercq (2019) terms *le bon usage French* (as based on Grevisse & Goosse 1993 and Rooryck 2017), the formal, written variety of the language in which *ne* is still required to express sentential negation. With regards to the spoken variety, it is well-known that speakers tend to omit this marker nowadays. This omission leads to two predictions: either that ExN will disappear from the language over time, or that it will assimilate with the 'new' negator *pas*. At present, the second outcome seems more likely as it is already attested in, for instance, Quebec French, where *ne* has largely been dropped and *pas* has become the real *and* expletive negator (cf. Gonzalez & Royer 2022, Labelle 2023).

lenge. Despite being considered non-negative in meaning, ExN is, under current assumptions, expected to belong to the same FSEQ as standard and modal negation, and to even be associated with features related to it. This raises questions about the precise nature of its structural representation and its connection to other types of negation.

The aims of this paper are thus twofold. On the one hand, we wish to investigate the semantic contribution of ExN and determine its position within the negative FSEQ, and on the other, we want to provide a uniform, formal analysis that accounts for the observed patterns of syncretism between ExN and real negation. Building on earlier proposals by Makri (2013) and Tsiakmakis & Espinal (2022), we argue that ExN is not semantically empty but can convey modal meaning - presumably epistemic in nature - when embedded under *fear*-predicates. Accordingly, we propose that ExN occupies a high modal projection, closely related to Speech Act (cf. Tsiakmakis & Espinal 2022, Krifka 2024). To address the syncretisms, we adopt the Nanosyntactic model of lexicalisation as well as the tool of so-called 'complex left branches'. Taking the implementation of these particular structures in De Clercq (2019) for French negation as a starting point, we demonstrate that the three attested patterns fall out naturally from the lexical specifications of individual negators in each language, and that the variation we see on the surface simply arises from the many ways in which each language lexicalises the same underlying FSEQ. This is very much in line with the more traditional idea in contemporary linguistic theory that syntactic operations/structures are universal and that (cross-linguistic) grammatical variation should be attributed to the properties of lexical items only (cf. Borer-Chomsky conjecture in Borer 1984).

The paper is organised as follows. In Section 2, we begin by discussing the patterns in greater detail, presenting data from a range of typologically diverse languages. In Section 3, we then explore the semantic contribution of ExN in *fear*-clauses, reviewing some of the core arguments in the literature favouring an epistemic reading. In Section 4, after establishing ExN as a modal marker, we briefly introduce Nanosyntax and its core principles, as well as the notion of complex left branches. In Section 5 we show how the patterns are derived, using French, Modern Greek and Czech as examples. Finally, we conclude the paper in Section 6.

2 Data

Abstracting away from the fine-grained distinctions in the Introduction, we have identified three cross-linguistic patterns of syncretism so far between ExN and instances of real negation: (i) between the standard NEG1, the modal NEG2 and ExN, (ii) between the modal NEG2 and ExN, and (iii) between a segment of a bipartite negator and ExN. In this section, we present data from a number of languages that illustrate these patterns. Note, however, that this list is by no means exhaustive. A more comprehensive overview can be found in, for instance, Jin & Koenig (2021) and Demonie and Baunaz, in prep, as well as Demonie, in prep.

2.1 Pattern 1: NEG1 = NEG2 = E*x*N

The first pattern involves syncretism across the board. That is, there is no morphological distinction between NEG1, NEG2 or ExN; they are all realised by the same morpheme. We have already seen an example of this pattern in Czech, (1), repeated here in (2), with the addition of modal negation.[4,5]

(2) (Czech, Polomská, p.c. and Dočekal 2012)

a. Karel **ne**-přišel na oslavu.
Karel NEG-came.PAST to party
'Karel didn't come to the party.' (NEG1)

b. **Ne**-přijde na oslavu!
NEG-come.PERF to party
'Don't come to the party!' (NEG2)

c. Petr se bál, aby Karel **ne**-přišel.
Peter REFL feared that-SBJV Karel EXN-came.PAST
'Peter was afraid that Karel would come.' (ExN)

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[4]Unless stated otherwise, the negative markers used for prohibitives and/or softer negative commands are also used for all the other cases of modal negation.

[5]To our knowledge, all languages exhibiting Pattern 1 express negative *fear*-clauses by shifting the mood or modality of the embedded clause to the indicative, or to something comparable that conveys epistemic certainty (e.g., the complementiser in Slavic languages or Basque). The negator remains the same regardless.

This pattern is quite prevalent across Slavic languages. For instance, it is also attested in East Slavic languages, such as Russian, (3), as well as in South Slavic languages, such as Bulgarian, (4). Jin & Koenig (2021) also mention Polish, Ukrainian, Serbo-Croatian and Slovenian.

(3) (Russian, Sergienko, p.c. and Dobrushina 2020).

a. On **ne** chital knigu.
he NEG read.PAST.SG book.ACC
'He didn't read the book.' (NEG1)

b. **Ne** zakhodi sjuda
NEG walk-IMP.2SG here
'Don't go in here.' (NEG2)

c. Bojus' kak by syn **ne** zabolel
fear-1SG how SBJV son EXN fall.ill-PAST.SG
'I am afraid that my son might get ill.' (EXN)

(4) (Bulgarian, own data)

a. Moryak na sushata **ne** pluva.
Sailor on land NEG swim
'A sailor on land does not swim.' (NEG1)

b. **Ne** idvaĭ na svatbata!
NEG come.IMP.2SG to wedding
'Don't come to the wedding!' (NEG2)

c. Mnogo se strakhuvakhme da **ne** doĭde
Much REFL fear-PAST.1PL SBJV EXN come.PRES.3SG
nyakoya u doma ili nyakŭde nablizo.
someone to house or somewhere nearby
'We were very afraid that someone would
come to our house or somewhere nearby.' (EXN)

Beyond Slavic languages, this pattern also occurs in a number of Romance languages, although to a much lesser extent in *fear*-clauses. Nevertheless, see the examples from Catalan in (5) and from European Portuguese in (6).

(5) (Catalan, own data and Tsiakmakis & Espinal 2022)

a. **No** va llegir fins als 9 anys
NEG PST.AUX.3SG read.INF until to.the 9 years
'He/She didn't read until the age of 9.' (NEG1)

b. **No** parlis de mi quan me'n
NEG speak.IMP.2SG of me when CL.1SG=PART
vagi
go.SBJV.1SG
'Don't talk about me when I leave.' (NEG2)

c. Tinc por que **no** es mengin el pastís.
have.1SG fear that EXN CL eat.SBJV.3PL the cake
'I'm afraid that they might/will eat the cake.' (EXN)

(6) (Portuguese, own data and Ramat 2022)

a. Ele **não** gostou do filme
he NEG like.PST.3SG of.the film
'He didn't like the film.' (NEG1)

b. **Não** comas!
NEG eat.SBJV.2SG
'Don't eat!' (NEG2)

c. Juan teme que ela **não** esteja doente
Juan fears that she EXN be.SBJV.3SG sick
'Juan fears that she is sick.' (EXN)

Lastly, we also include two examples from typologically distinct languages. Consider the data from the North-Caucasian language Abkhaz in (7), and from the isolate Basque in (8).

(7) (Abkhaz, Hewitt 2005, Chirikba in press)

a. sar wa sə-g^{j}ə-cá-**m**
I there I-EMPH-go-NEG
'I do not go there.' (NEG1)

b. ha-wə-**mə**-rə́-pxaš^{j}ə-n
us-YOU(M)-NEG-CAUS-be ashamed-IMPER
'Don't make us be ashamed!' (NEG2)

c. də.**m.**'psə.ø.nda((.)z) xəa
(s)he.EXN.die.PAST=N/F-AOR.OPT fear
sj^{w}a.wa.jt'
I.fear.DYN.FIN(=PRES)
'I am afraid that (s)he will die.' (EXN)

(8) (Basque, Hualde & Ortiz de Urbina 2003)

a. Zer esan **ez** dakizunean, höbe duzu
what say NEG know.when better have.3A/2E
ixiltzea.
hush.NOM.DET
'When you don't know what to say,
you'd better be silent.' (NEG1)

b. **Ez** hadi/zaitez(te) etorri.
NEG AUX.IMP come
'Don't come!' (NEG2)

c. Beldur naiz [berandu iritsi **ez** ote den].
fear AUX late arrive EXN PTCL AUX.COMP
'I fear that he arrived late.' (EXN)

2.2 *Pattern 2:* NEG2 = EXN

The second pattern distinguishes itself from the first one in two ways: the relevant languages have one or more different markers for NEG1 and NEG2, and EXN is exclusively syncretic with the morphological NEG2 marker.

In terms of distribution, this pattern is not really tied to specific language families. It appears, for instance, in Modern Greek, (9), where a distinction is made between the standard marker *dhen* and the modal one *min*. Note, however, that the cut-off point between those two markers is between CC and VOL (cf. Table 2), and that EXN takes the same form as NEG2 *min*.[6,7]

(9) (Modern Greek, Giannakidou 1998, Chatzopoulou 2013, Baunaz & Lander 2023)

a. O Jánis **dhen**/*min írthe
the J. NEG1/NEG2 came.3SG
'John did not come.' (NEG1)

[6] There are several contexts (e.g., polar questions) in which *dhen* does not seem to contribute semantic negation either, but Tsiakmakis (2025) demonstrates that these are merely apparent cases of EXN.

[7] As far as we know, Pattern 2 languages seem to retain the option to express negative *fear*-clauses by shifting the mood from subjunctive to indicative (or from epistemically weak to epistemically strong), but they need to swap NEG2 for NEG1 as well. Alternatively, several languages also allow the additional option of stacking EXN and NEG1 without changing anything else. See, for instance, the Modern Greek example in (21). Similar examples can also be found in Albanian and Latin.

b. **Min**/*dhen eísai vlákas!
NEG2/NEG1 be.2SG stupid
'Don't be stupid!' (NEG2)

c. Fovame (na) **min**/*dhen érthi
fear.1SG (SBJV) EXN come.PNP.3SG
'I fear s/he may come.' (ExN)

This pattern can also be found in Mandarin Chinese, as shown in (10). The sole difference between this language and Modern Greek is that *bú* covers more ground than *dhen*, realising everything up until VOL. ExN is still only syncretic with NEG2 *bié*.[8]

(10) (Chinese, Pan et al. 2016, Jin & Koenig 2019, De Clercq 2020)

a. Tā **bú**/*biè shì kuàilè
3SG NEG1/NEG2 COP happy
'She is not happy.' (NEG1)

b. Nǐ **bié**/*bú shuāi zhe le
you NEG2/NEG1 fall.down DUR PFV
'Don't fall down.' (NEG2)

c. Wǒ pà míngtiān Duōlúnduō **biè**/*bú xià-yǔ
1SG fear tomorrow Toronto EXN fall-rain
'I fear that it will rain tomorrow in Toronto.' (ExN)

Likewise, the pattern also appears in a variety of other languages, such as Albanian, (5), Hindi-Urdu, (12), and Latin (see Table 2 and *infra* 4). In each of these languages, the cut-off points between the negative markers differ as well. In Albanian, *nuk* expresses standard as well as PC negation, whereas *mos* realises the remaining projections - CC, VOL and PROH. In Hindi-Urdu, the division aligns more neatly with the boundary between T and MOD-NEG: *nahII* acts as the standard negator, and *na* as the modal negator. There is also a third modal negator, *mat*, which is restricted to honorific negative commands, but we exclude it from the discussion here. Finally, Latin exhibits a three-way distinction as well, with *non* expressing the negative features up to PC, and *ne* being

[8] We follow here De Clercq (2020) in considering *bú* as the main negator in Mandarin Chinese, with the other common negator, *méi yǒu* (lit: 'not (have)') being more restricted in its distribution (i.e., perfective, existential and possessive contexts).

the marker of VOL and PROH. *Ni* is used exclusively for CC and is also set aside in this discussion. Nevertheless, EXN is consistently syncretic with NEG2 in all these cases.

(11) (Albanian, Turano 2000, Tahar 2021)

a. **Nuk**/*mos vajta në bibliotekë
NEG1/NEG2 go-1SG.PST in library
'I did not go to the library.' (NEG1)

b. **Mos**/*nuk më ndihmo!
NEG2/NEG1 1SG.DAT help-IMP
'Don't help me!' (NEG2)

c. Kam frikë se **mos**/*nuk më vdes babai
have-1SG fear that NEG2 CL.1SG die-3SG father-DEF
'I fear that my father will die.' (EXN)

(12) (Hindi-Urdu, McGregor 1978, Lampp 2006)

a. ...mAI hinsa tathaa logo kii hatya mE
I slaughter and people-PL GEN murder in
bharosaa **nahII**/*na rakhtaa
faith NEG1/NEG2 keep.PRS
'I don't believe in the slaughter and murder of people.'
(NEG1)

b. DaakTarone Vaajpeyii se kahaa hai ki ve kuch
doctors-ERG Vajpayee TO said AUX.PRES that he some
dino tak apne pAav-o par zyaadaa bhaar **na**/*nahII
day-PL for REFL foot-PL on too.much weight NEG2/NEG1
Daale
put-SBJV
'Doctors have told Vajpayee that for a few
days he shouldn't strain his feet.' (NEG2)

c. Muhje dar tha ki kaheen sab pustaken gir
me-DAT fear was-M that perhaps all books-F fall
na/*nahII jaem
EXN might.OPT.AUX
'I was afraid that all the books might fall.' (EXN)

(13) (Latin, Var, Ling. 5.8.77, Pl. Ep. 145, Cic. Leg. 1-4)

a. …ut poeta facit fabulam et
…like poet-NOM make.3SG.PRES play-ACC and
non/*ne agit
NEG1/NEG2 act.3SG.PRES

'…like the poet makes a play
and does not act it.' (NEG1)

b. Meam domum **ne**/*non imbitas
POSS.1SG house NEG2/NEG1 enter-2SG.SBJV
'Don't enter my house!' (NEG2)

c. Timeo **ne**/*non laborem augeam
fear-1SG.PRS NEG2/NEG1 work-ACC increase-1SG.SBJV
'I'm afraid that I shall increase my work.' (EXN)

2.3 Pattern 3: NE…PAS

The third pattern concerns bipartite or discontinuous negation and its special relation to EXN. A textbook example of this type of negation can be found in French, (14).

(14) (French, own data)

a. Il (**ne**) pleut pas aujourd'hui.
It (NE) rain.3SG NEG1 today
'It doesn't rain today.'

b. (**Ne**) mange pas!
NE eat.IMP NEG1
'Don't eat!'

Diachronically, this is, of course, a classic illustration of the grammaticalisation process known as the Jespersen Cycle. *Ne* has gradually weakened over time and become reinforced by the newly emerging negator *pas*. This has led to the current situation where *pas* is the only carrier of negative force. Synchronically, several diagnostics also confirm that *ne* is indeed no longer negative. For example, while *pas* triggers double negation readings in co-occurrence with negative polarity items (NPI), *ne* alone cannot trigger such effects, as shown in (15).

(15) (French NPI, adapted from Zeijlstra 2010)

a. Personne **ne** mange
nobody NEG eat.3SG
'Nobody eats.'

b. Personne **ne** mange **pas**
nobody NEG eat.3SG NEG

'Nobody doesn't eat / Nobody does not eat.'

Moreover, in the spoken language, *ne* is frequently omitted due to its perceived redundancy, further supporting the view that it has become an expletive element. Consequently, we only see *ne* appearing (optionally) as an ExN marker in *fear*-clauses, as shown in (16).

(16) (French, own data)

J'ai	peur	qu'il	(**ne**)	pleuve	demain.
I.have	fear	that.he	EXN	rain.SBJV	tomorrow

'I fear that it will rain tomorrow.' (ExN)

With regards to other languages with bipartite negation, the prediction that follows from the French data is that they have grammaticalised or will grammaticalise their weakened negative marker into an ExN marker, especially if they are undergoing the various stages of the Jespersen Cycle. Alternatively, they might also turn into a Pattern 1 language where everything ends up being syncretic (cf. footnote 2)

Unfortunately, while bipartite negation occurs in a considerable number of languages, including contemporary ones like the Italo-Romance Emilian, alpine Lombard and Piedmontese-Ligurian varieties (cf. Parry 2013), as well as historical ones, like Early Middle English (cf. Wallage 2005), data on ExN in those languages are scarce, if not entirely undocumented. This naturally limits the possibilities to verify any of the predictions, at least for now.

There is, however, one language that seems to resemble the French pattern. The Celtic language, Breton, uses the bipartite marker *ne/na... ket* to express sentential negation (likely due to influence from French), as exemplified in (17). The part which is non-negative, *ne/na*, also appears in *fear*-clauses, as can be seen in (18).

(17) (Breton, Press 1986, Jouitteau 2005)

a.

Ne	sell	**ket**	james	Marijo	ouzh	an	dud
NEG	look.PRES.3SG	NEG	never	Marijo	on	the	people
war	ar	blasenn.					
on	the	square.SG					

'Marijo never looks at the people on the square.' (NEG)

b. **Na** selaouit **ket** ac'hanon
NEG listen.IMP NEG me
'Don't listen to me!' (NEG)

(18) (Breton, de Langlais 1975)
Gant aon **ne** vefe bet gwallgomzet c'hoazh.
with fear EXN would be speak.ill still
'He feared that he would still be spoken ill of.' (EXN)

2.4 *Interim summary*

To conclude this section, let us summarise the patterns we presented and elaborate on what they can tell us about the morphosyntactic position of EXN in the FSEQ.

Based on data from a number of related and unrelated languages, we identified three patterns of syncretism in the realisation of EXN in *fear*-clauses: one where EXN is syncretic all around, one where it is only syncretic with NEG2, and one where it is syncretic with the already expletive element of a bipartite marker. Table 4 provides a complete overview of the patterns in all the languages we discussed.

	ExN?	PROH	VOL	CC	PC	T	…
Abkhaz	-m(ə)	-m(ə)	-m(ə)	-m(ə)	-m(ə)	-m(ə)	…
Basque	ez	ez	ez	ez	ez	ez	…
Catalan	no	no	no	no	no	no	…
Czech	ne	ne	ne	ne	ne	ne	…
Portuguese	não	não	não	não	não	não	…
Hindi-Urdu	na	na	na	na	na	nahII	…
Albanian	mos	mos	mos	mos	nuk	nuk/s'	…
Modern Greek	min	min	min	dhen	dhen	dhen	…
Latin	ne	ne	ne	ni-	non	non	…
Mandarin Chinese	bié	bié	bù	bù	bù	bù	…
French	ne	ne… pas	ne…pas	ne…pas	ne…pas	ne…pas	…
Breton	ne	ne… ket	ne…ket	ne…ket	ne…ket	ne…ket	…

Table 4: Position of ExN

The syncretisms in Table 4 strongly suggest that EXN occupies a high position in the modal section of the FSEQ - specifically, the position adjacent to PROH, as this is the only one which respects the *ABA-restriction in every language. This is highlighted by the dark grey cells. They mark the cut-off points between morphologically distinct markers. As we can see, placing ExN in a lower, modal position - for example, between PROH and VOL - would create an ABA in French and Breton. Locating it even lower than that - between VOL and CC, between CC and PC, or between PC and T - would only introduce more ABAs, not just in French, but also in all the other languages which make use of two or more different markers. A high position for ExN thus seems to be the least problematic from a morphosyntactic perspective.

However, while the patterns of syncretism help us to determine the ordering of features and the position of ExN within the negative FSEQ, they do not, by themselves, reveal anything about the exact nature of ExN or about its apparent relationship to the modal domain. For this, we need to take a look at the semantic content of ExN

In the next section, we will review several diagnostics and arguments supporting the idea that ExN is indeed a modal element - more specifically, an epistemic one. Given that epistemic markers have been independently argued to occupy a position on the border between the modal and the C-domain by Tsiakmakis & Espinal (2022), the position suggested to us by the syncretisms will be shown to be well-motivated beyond mere morphological form.

3 Expletive negation is not expletive in *fear*-clauses

At present, there are two competing views in the literature regarding the (general) contribution of ExN: one which treats it as a genuinely negative element (cf. Tovena 1996, Abels 2005, Ürögdi 2013, Cépeda 2018, Delfitto 2020 amongst others), and another which analyses it as a modal element (cf. Yoon 2011, Makri 2013, 2016, Tsiakmakis et al. 2022,? amongst others).[9]

The main strength of the negative view lies in its parsimony. It does

[9]There used to be a third view which held that ExN is a true expletive element, i.e., a phonological form without semantic content (cf. Espinal 1992, 2000). However, this view has largely been abandoned in light of accumulating empirical evidence against it.

not require positing an extra, empty element - something which Abels (2005), in particular, regards as an unnecessary complication of the theory - and proponents of this view merely reconsider the scope that the negator takes; it scopes over the temporal ordering, the temporal interval, or even the pragmatic inference selected by the temporal clause, instead of over the proposition.[10]

However, despite the advantages that the negative view on ExN has, scholars that argue in favour of it are still forced to introduce additional theoretical machinery (e.g., movements in syntax and/or LF + conditions to constrain them to the right environments) to grapple with well-known empirical challenges, such as the fact that ExN fails to license NPIs, but is capable of licensing Positive Polarity Items (PPI) instead. This stands in contrast with real negation, for which we know that the opposite holds. Consider the difference between the Czech examples in (19) and (20).

(19) (Czech, adapted from Dočekal & Šafratová 2019)

a. Přijali každého lingvistu, který si
hire-PAST.3PL every linguist-ACC.SG who NEG-REFL
nepřečetl **ani** syntaktické struktury.
read-PAST.3PL even syntactic structure-ACC.PL
'They hired every linguist who had even read *Syntactic Structures*.' (NPI)

b. Přijali každého lingvistu, který si
hire-PAST.3PL every linguist-ACC.SG who REFL
nepřečetl *__i__ syntaktické struktury.
NEG-read-PAST.3PL even syntactic structure-ACC.PL
'They hired every linguist who had even read *Syntactic Structures*.' (PPI)

(20) (Czech, Lacina, p.c.)

a. Bojim se a-by nepřišel ***ani**
fear-1SG REFL COMP-SBJV EXN-come.PAST.3SG even
Pavel.
Pavel

[10] Their analyses mainly apply to the instances of ExN in temporal clauses and polar questions (cf. Tovena 1996,Ürögdi 2013,Cépeda 2018,Delfitto 2020 amongst others). As a discussion of these environments is out of the scope of the current paper, we will not elaborate on them here.

'Intended: I'm afraid that even Pavel would not come.' (NPI)

b. Bojim se a-by nepřišli Pavel **i** Petr.
   fear-1SG REFL COMP-SBJV EXN-come.PAST.3PL Pavel even Peter
   'I'm afraid that even Pavel would not come' (PPI)

Whereas the NPI *ani* ('even') can be licensed by negation in a regular context, such as (19a), its PPI counterpart *i* ('even') is ungrammatical under the same conditions, (19b). Conversely, *ani* is disallowed in *fear*-clauses, such as (20a), and *i* is perfectly grammatical, (20b).

A second, related challenge is that some languages allow ExN to co-occur with NEG1 to turn the embedded clause negative again. With the addition of NEG1, NPIs are also successfully licensed. Consider, for instance, the Modern Greek example in (21).

(21) (Modern Greek, Tsiakmakis 2025)

a. *Fovame **min** **ø** efaye tipota o babas
   I.fear NEG2 ø ate nothing the dad

b. Fovame **min** **dhen** efaye tipota o babas
   I.fear NEG2 NEG1 ate nothing the dad
   'I fear dad maybe didn't eat anything.'

As expected, the NPI *tipota* ('nothing') in (21a), cannot be licensed by ExN alone (see also Roussou 2015). However, when the NEG1 *dhen* enters the picture, *tipota* becomes sensitive to its negative force and becomes grammatical. Cases of stacking, like the one in Modern Greek, thus seem to suggest that ExN does not contribute semantic negation by itself, but needs an additional clause-mate negator that has access to the proposition.

Given these and similar challenges, we rather adopt the alternative view in this paper. In this view, ExN is no longer conceived of as a negative marker, and as such, it is easier to circumvent the empirical issues mentioned above; if ExN lacks negative force altogether, it naturally fails to exhibit any of the properties that real negation has. Crucially, however, this does not mean that ExN is considered semantically empty. It is still argued to have interpretable meaning, most notably epistemic modal meaning. This hypothesis is particularly well-motivated for *fear*-clauses, both empirically and theoretically.

For starters, while deontic modal adverbials, such as *nužno* ('necessary') in (22), may co-occur with EXN, it has been observed that other modal adverbials such as *probably* or *maybe*, are incompatible with it. Makri (2013), for instance, illustrates this by means of the Modern Greek examples in (23).

(22) (Russian, Sergienko, p.c.)

Ja bojus', kak by emu **ne** **nužno** bylo
I fear.1SG how SBJV him.DAT EXN necessary be.PST.PTCP
ujti s večerinki
leave.INF from party
'I'm afraid that it is necessary that he leaves'

(23) (Modern Greek, Makri 2013)

a. Fovame **min (*malon)** troi pola ghlika
fear.1SG EXN probably eat.3SG many sweets

b. Fovame oti malon troi pola ghlika
fear.1SG that probably eat.3SG many sweets
'I fear that he maybe eats a lot of candy.'

As shown in (23a), *min* cannot appear alongside the adverb *malon* ('probably'). Makri explains this incompatibility by arguing that both markers express the same type of modality and are therefore in complementary distribution. Specifically, she claims that *min* and *malon* have lower epistemic functions. As such, it is predicted that *malon* is fine whenever *min* is omitted - a prediction which is borne out in (23b).

A similar observation has also been made by Baunaz et al. (2024) for French, as shown in (24). Here too, we see that the epistemic modal adverb *peut-être* ('maybe') is unacceptable in the presence of expletive *ne*. And although the sentence remains somewhat awkward, the acceptability improves noticeably when *ne* is left out.

(24) (French, own data)

a. J'ai peur que (***peut-être**) Marie ne parte
I-have fear that perhaps Marie EXN leave.SBJV
(***peut-être**)
perhaps

b. ?J'ai peur que (**peut-être**) Marie parte (**peut-être**)
I-have fear that perhaps Marie leave.SBJV perhaps
'I'm afraid that Marie will perhaps leave.'

Beyond this diagnostic, Makri (2013, 2016) also demonstrates that ExN neutralises the doxastic possibilities of a proposition, meaning it effectively eliminates the speaker's commitment to a particular stance regarding the truth-value of that proposition. This property makes ExN incompatible with questions that enquire about said truth-value. She gives the examples in (25).

(25) (Modern Greek, Makri 2013, 2016)

a. Erhete o Nikos? — Fovame pos erhete.
come.3SG the Nikos — fear.1SG that come.3SG
'Is Nikos coming? — I fear that he is.'

b. Erhete o Nikos? — Fovame #**min** erhete.
come.3SG the Nikos — fear.1SG EXN come.3SG
'Is Nikos coming? — I'm afraid that he is coming.'

As we can see, a regular *fear*-clause including the complementiser *pos* ('that'), can serve as a felicitous answer to a polar question, (25a), indicating that the speaker considers the embedded proposition to be likely or, at least, probable.[11] However, as shown in (25b), a *fear*-clause including *min* is an infelicitous response, suggesting that ExN does not convey the same commitment to the truth-value of the embedded proposition, thus causing the incompatibility between *min* and its immediate environment. This outcome again reinforces the view for Makri that ExN is an epistemic marker, albeit one which leaves the speaker neither certain nor uncertain about the truth of the proposition.

While Makri's claim that ExN is an epistemic marker has remained unchallenged, the more specific one that it encodes epistemic neutrality has been slightly adjusted in light of more recent experimental results. Tsiakmakis et al. (2022), for instance, conducted several experiments in which they asked the participants to evaluate the speaker's degree of certainty with regards to the truth of the proposition. Their results,

[11] The declarative complementiser pos ('that') is used interchangeably with the complementiser *oti* ('that') in spoken Modern Greek, see Roussou 2015 for details

instead of showing total ignorance about the proposition, rather pointed to a moderate or medium speaker's bias. That is, participants were inclined to believe that the proposition was true, but remained, to a degree, uncertain.

A similar observation has again been made for French, where the expletive marker *ne* - contrary to popular belief - also appears to signal an epistemic stance toward the embedded proposition. Building on Tahar's (2021) work, which argues that French *fear*-predicates are ambiguous between an epistemic and an emotive reading, Baunaz et al. (2024) conducted an experiment showing that *ne* may only surface under the epistemic one.

Concretely, they designed an acceptability task in which they added intensifying adverbs, such as *très* ('very') and *tellement* ('so much') to the original *fear*-clauses in order to manipulate the intensity of the emotive state of the subject. What they found is that speakers tend to reject the modification of the *fear*-predicate by these adverbs whenever *ne* is present, (26). If *fear*-predicates indeed consist of two semantic layers, one being emotive and another being epistemic, these findings suggest that *ne* is only compatible with the epistemic layer (*contra* Mari & Tahar 2020 and Tahar 2021)[12].

(26) (French, own data)

a. J'ai peur que Marie (ne) vienne.
   I-have fear that Mary (EXN) come.SBJV

b. J'ai **très** peur que Marie (*ne) vienne.
   I-have very fear that Mary (*EXN) come.SBJV

c. J'ai **tellement** peur que Marie (*ne) vienne.
   I-have so.much fear that Mary (*EXN) come.SBJV

Taking into account the semantic profile of ExN discussed in this section,

[12] see also Dikmen, Baunaz and Demonie (under review) for more details on the semantic nature of ExN in French. In that paper, we counter the idea that French *ne* is semantically vacuous and/or optional. Instead, we propose that *fear*-clauses featuring *ne* are semantically closer in nature to indicatives and those without *ne* are semantically subjunctive. Additionally, we argue that *fear*-predicates come in two different guises, belief and emotive/volitive (in a similar spirit as Tahar (2021)) and each of those selects only one of the two types of embedded clauses. Belief-*fear* seems the only one compatible with *ne*.

as well as the patterns of syncretism we observed in the previous section, we are now in a better position to argue that ExN indeed occupies a high, epistemic position - specifically, in between the modal and C-domain in the clausal spine. We will refer to this position as EPIST in the remainder of the paper.[13]

Seeing how we can now tie ExN to a specific semantic contribution as well as syntactic position, the remaining task is to unite real and expletive negation without attributing a negative value to the latter. To achieve this, we will adopt the Nanosyntactic model of lexicalisation and make use of the particular tool of complex left branches, as implemented specifically in De Clercq (2019).

4 Nanosyntax

Now, that we have established which forms ExN may take cross-linguistically and which position it likely takes up in the FSEQ based on its semantic properties and the available syncretisms, we can proceed with the analysis. However, before going over the derivation of the three patterns, it is necessary to outline several of the core principles and mechanisms of Nanosyntax, the theoretical framework our analysis is couched in.

4.1 General

Nanosyntax (Starke 2009, Caha 2009, Baunaz & Lander 2018, De Clercq et al. in press) is a Late Insertion theory of morphology in which syn-

[13]This position has also been referred to as Judge(ment) Phrase in earlier work by Tsiakmakis & Espinal (2022) and Krifka (2024). It represents epistemic and evidential attitudes of the speaker and forms a part of a more fine-grained decomposition of the left periphery into multiple Speech-Act layers. The syntactic template of this structure is provided in (i). However, since our primary goal is to provide a uniform analysis of the syncretisms, we will not dwell on the finer details of this structure or the syntactic operations that come with it, as these are beyond the scope of this paper. The relevant phrase is indicated by the box.

(i) $[_{\text{ActP}} [_{\text{Act'}} [_{\text{Act}_o} \text{ASSERT}] [_{\text{ComP}} [_{\text{Com'}} [_{\text{Com}_o} \vdash] [\boxed{_{\text{JP}} [_{\text{J'}} [_{\text{J}^o} \text{J–}]]} [_{\text{TP}} \text{p}]]]]]$

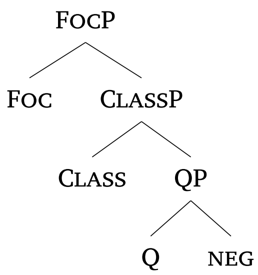
tactic structures are assumed to be merged prior to lexicalisation. As a result, lexical items are considered links between a phonological representation, a semantic concept (optional), and a syntactic tree with abstract features. To illustrate this, let us use the sentential and constituent negators in Albanian.

	T	Foc	Class	Q	Neg
Albanian	nuk	jo	jo	jo	

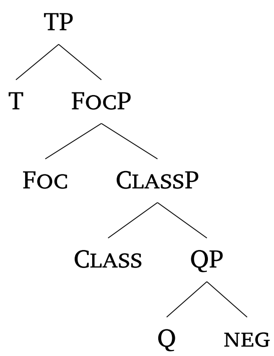
Table 5: Albanian standard negation

Albanian has two distinct negative markers: *jo* which is used to negate degree adjectives, (Q), classifying adjectives, (CLASS), and focused constituents, (FOC), and *nuk* which is used to negate tensed predicates, (T), (cf. Turano 2000, Baunaz & Lander 2023).[14] As such, their lexical items take the forms in (27). Each feature represents a full phrase.

(27) a. */jo/* ⟺



b. */nuk/* ⟺

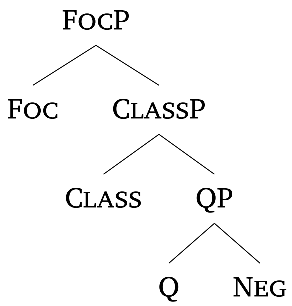


In this conception, lexicalisation is conceived of as a matching process between the structures merged by syntax and the ones contained within

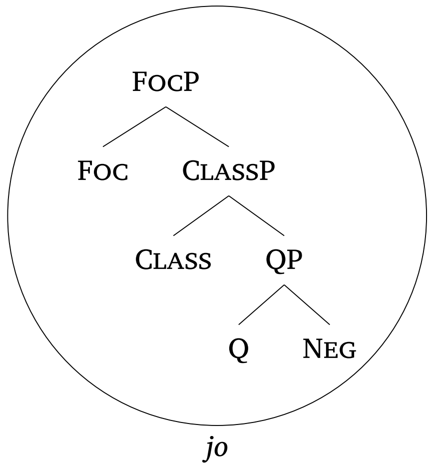
[14] Albanian actually has two markers for sentential negation, *nuk* and *s'*, that have been described as interchangeable (cf. Turano 2000). For the sake of simplicity, we only represent one of them.

each lexical item. That is, each time syntax builds a particular structure, it consults the lexicon for a lexical item containing a structure that is identical to it (a requirement formulated as the *Condition on Matching* in De Clercq et al. (in press))). Applied to Albanian negation, this means that when syntax merges the features for focus negation, as in (28a), *jo* is a possible candidate to lexicalise it, because its lexical structure is identical to it. We indicate successful lexicalisations with circles, as in (28b).

(28) a.

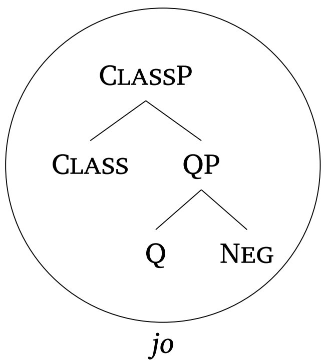


b.

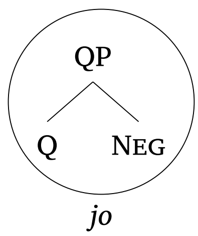


Identity also extends to matching subconstituents. That is, any given lexical item may, in principle, lexicalise a syntactic structure that is perfectly contained within its lexical structure. This is known as the Superset Effect. With regards to Albanian again, this means that *jo* can also be inserted at the height of CLASS or Q, (29).

(29) a.

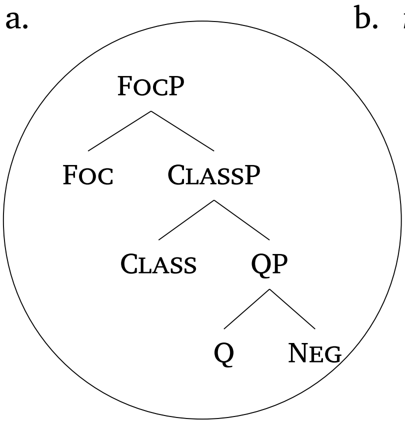


b.

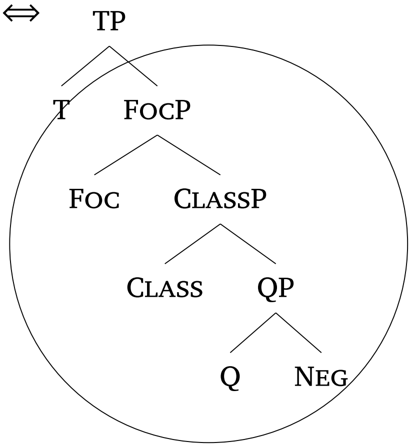


However, a second constraint is required, because the identity condition alone would also allow the sentential negator *nuk/s'* to lexicalise the trees in (28)-(29), due to a partial match between the structures, (30). This would clearly yield incorrect outcomes.

(30) a.



b. *nuk/s'* ⇔



To resolve situations like this, where multiple lexical items are eligible candidates for lexicalisation, the Elsewhere Condition (cf. Kiparsky 1973, De Clercq et al. in press) is invoked. According to this condition, the lexical item with the most fitting match, i.e., the one that has the fewest additional (unused) features, is always preferred over the other one(s). In the Albanian case, *jo* therefore takes precedence over *nuk/s'* in the lexicalisation of constituent negation, as it yields a more economical match for the features up to foc. Only when t is merged, does *nuk/s'* override it. This is summarised in Table 6

T	Foc	Class	Q	Neg
	jo			
nuk/s'				

Table 6: Albanian lexicalisation table

The Albanian example also sheds light on how Nanosyntax deals with both intra- and cross-linguistic variation. Under the current approach, variation arises from differences in the feature specifications of individual lexical items. Specifically, some items store more (syntactic) information than others. This leads to the diversity of lexicalisation patterns we observe on the surface. While the underlying fseq remains constant, languages differ in how they realise this structure: a given

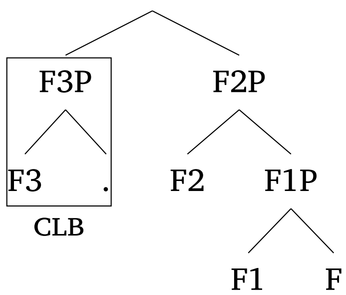
FSEQ may be lexicalised by a single morpheme in one given language, resulting in syncretism, but by multiple morphemes in another.

4.2 *Complex left branches*

Since lexical items are essentially conceived of as snapshots of syntactic structures, they can vary in size, but also in shape. While some have a relatively simple, cumulative organisation (as we have seen for Albanian), others have a more complex internal structure, involving either the movement of a particular subconstituent (cf. *Movement Containing Trees* in Blix (2021) and *Subextractions* in De Clercq et al. (in press)), or the merging of a new derivation (cf. Starke (2018)). In this paper, we make use of the latter type: the so-called 'complex left branches' (CLB).

Without getting too technical, a CLB is essentially a full, self-standing constituent which is first built in a separate workspace and subsequently attached to the main derivation, as illustrated in (31). In this sense, they are comparable to complex specifiers in traditional syntax. CLBs are used as a last-resort strategy when standard derivational operations (like *Merge* or *Move*) do not lead to the lexicalisation of a particular feature.[15]

(31)



The tree in (31) is an example of a syntactic structure containing a CLB. Following the description above, F3P forms its own constituent in a separate derivation, after which it is merged together with the main

[15]Derivations in Nanosyntax follow a strict procedure known as the *Lexicalisation Algorithm*. It consists of an ordered sequence of operations, including *Merge*, *Move* and, ultimately, *Merge-XP*. For the purposes of this paper, however, it suffices to know what CLBs are and how they are lexicalised (see *infra* and Section 5). For a more elaborate discussion of the algorithm and the specific step involving CLBs, we refer the reader to Starke (2018) and De Clercq et al. (in press).

derivation composed of F2P, and F1P.[16] In terms of the empirical application of these CLB, they are mainly employed in the context of preposed elements, such as prefixes, pronouns, complementisers, and most relevant to the current discussion, also negation. One particular account we highlight here is the one by De Clercq (2019). In what follows, we will briefly relay her work on French bipartite negation to provide a more concrete illustration and set the scene for our own analysis.

If we recall, French sentential negation is made up of two markers, *ne* and *pas*. Even though the former is considered expletive and to some extent redundant, De Clercq observes that it must still accompany the latter in order to express sentential negation. Consider the examples in (32) and (33).[17]

(32) (French)

Cette maladie est soignable, mais **PAS** supportable.
the disease is curable but NEG bearable

'The disease is curable, but not bearable.'

(33) ([Bon usage] French)

a. #Je mange **pas**.
I eat NEG1

'I don't eat.'

b. *Je **ne** mange.
I NEG1 eat

'Intended: I don't eat.'

In (32), *pas* can negate the adjective *supportable* without the aid of the other marker *ne*, effectively expressing focus negation or constituent

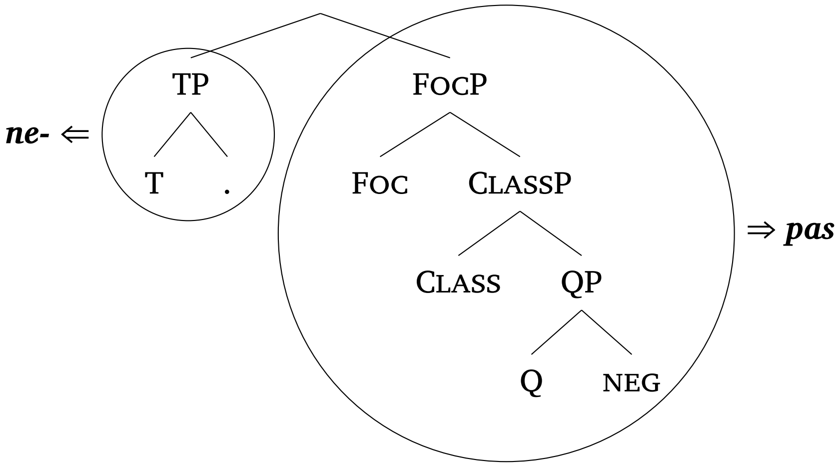
[16]The dot to the left of F3 marks the fact that CLBs are merged entirely independently from the main derivation, or in other words, that they start from an empty (semantic) set. This marking has been fairly recently added to the theory by Michal Starke, in his 2024 fall seminar taught at the Masaryk University. Prior to this, CLBs were also proposed to be direct continuations of the main derivation, copying its last feature - in this case that would be FOC - and merging that one with the new feature - in this case T (cf. Caha et al. 2019).

[17]Recall that this only applies to formal French; (33) is grammatical in informal/spoken French. In the spoken variety, the lexical item of *pas* has grown to incorporate the tense feature, thus getting rid of the need to complement it by *ne*.

negation. In contrast, in (33), neither *pas* nor *ne* are capable of expressing sentential negation on their own without yielding an ungrammatical result.

In De Clercq's view, this shows that both negative markers are lexically deficient, and must complement each other to realise sentential negation. She structurally captures this complementation by means of a CLB structure, as shown in (34).

(34)



As we can see in (34), the lexical item of *pas* is assumed to contain and lexicalise all the features up to FOC. As such, it also carries the negative value. Importantly, however, it lacks the tense feature T, meaning it cannot realise sentential negation. The lexical item of *ne*, on the other hand, is only associated with T, enabling it to complement *pas*, but not to express anything negative.

Even though these structures differ in form from the ones we have seen so far, the same conditions for lexicalisation apply. Syntax will still search for a match with a (sub)constituent of the structure, and, as before, smaller lexical items will take precedence over bigger ones. The key differences, however, lie in the configuration of the FSEQ, (i.e., some part of it is put in a CLB), and in the possibility of allowing a kind of disjoint lexicalisation of it. In the case of French bipartite negation, this happens by means of two separate lexical items, but as we will see in the next section, this idea can be extended to include single lexical items.

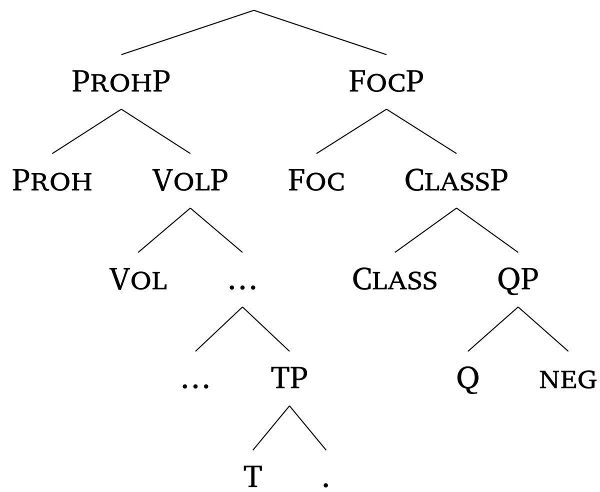
5 Analysis

In this final section, we will turn to the analysis of the three patterns of syncretism, repeated below. For reasons of space, we will focus on Czech, Modern Greek and French, the representative languages introduced earlier, with the understanding that the analysis extends to other languages of the same type. We begin with French, as we already established the baseline for it in the previous section.

- pattern 1: Languages where ExN is syncretic with neg1 *and* neg2, (e.g. Czech)
- pattern 2: Languages where ExN is syncretic with neg2 only, (e.g. Modern Greek)
- pattern 3: Languages where (ExN is syncretic with the first part of a bipartite negator, (e.g. French)

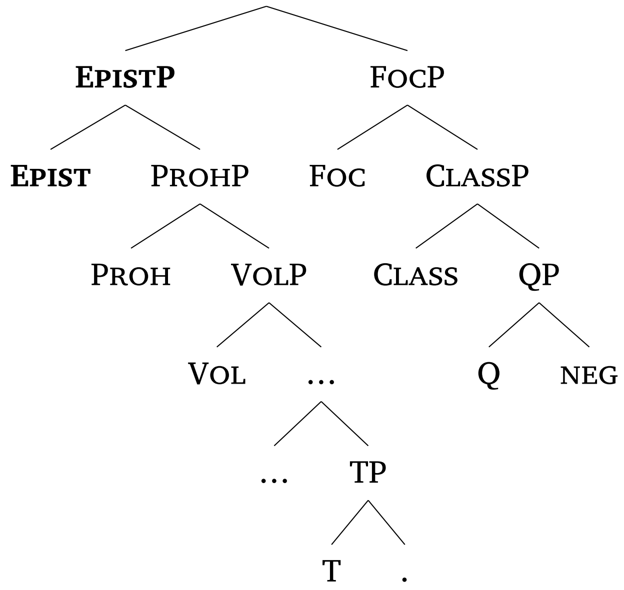
First of all, we expand the complex structure proposed in De Clercq's work to include modal negation. Following her own suggestion in the article, as well as the fact that there is a morphological divide in French between the constituent and sentential negator, this extension is added on the left branch for French, as shown in (35). Recall that the modal negative projection was also decomposed into a set of features by Baunaz & Lander (2023), covering the range from possibility conditionals to prohibitives.

(35)



As proposed, EXN, or EPIST, as we will refer to it, sits above PROH in the FSEQ, as shown in (36). This is the full structure we assume for French NEG and EXN.

(36)



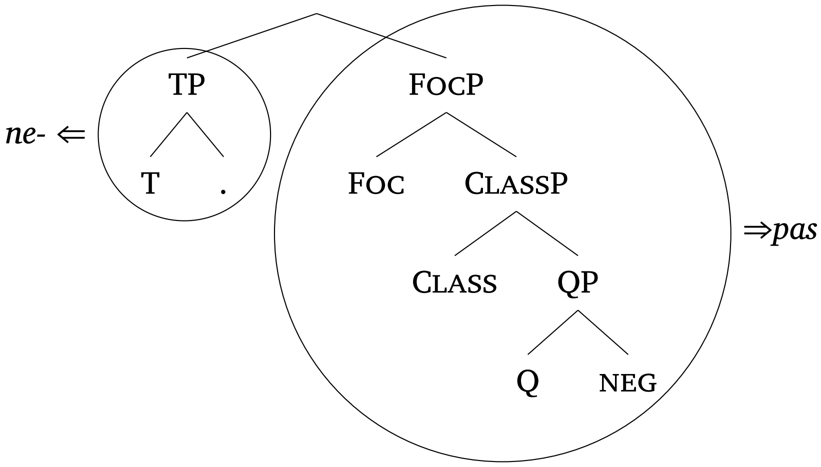
How then, is this structure lexicalised? Let us illustrate with a few possible constructions, starting with a simple negative sentence, like (37).

(37) (French)

Je **ne** mange **pas**.
I EXN eat NEG1
'I don't eat.'

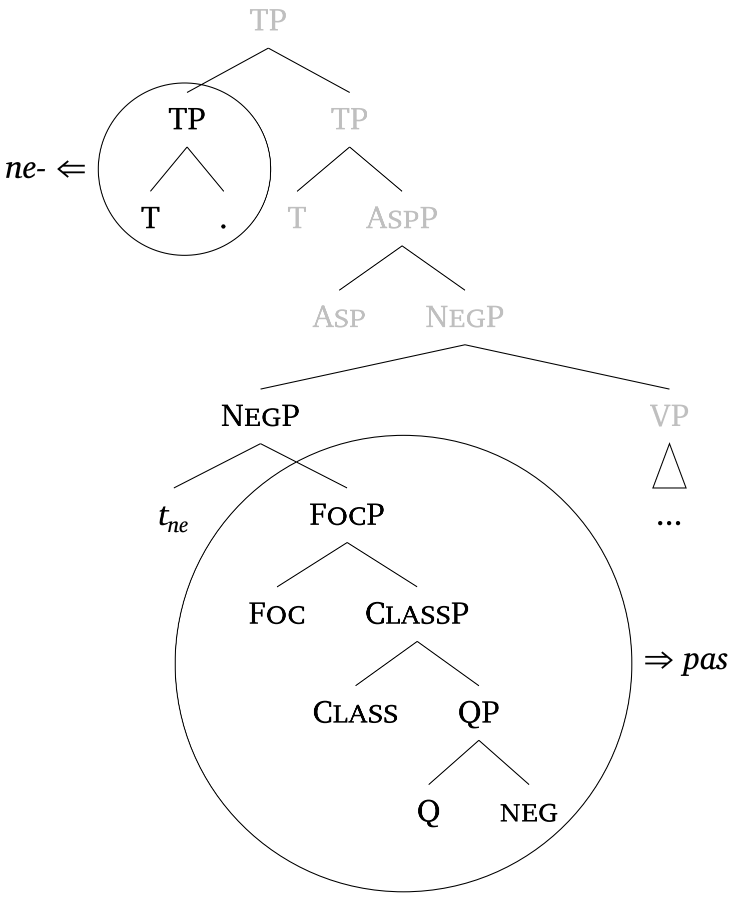
In this case, the CLB that we have already encountered in (34), and repeated in (38), will be employed, with *ne* lexicalising T and *pas* the main NEG spine. Recall that both are capable of exponing their respective branches, because their lexical structures match those of the syntactic structures, either perfectly in the case of *pas*, or partially in the case of *ne*.

(38)



In the broader, syntactic environment, both *ne* and *pas* are then likely merged in a low NegP position, from where *ne* moves upward to T at a later stage, either in response to a certain syntactic feature requirement, (e.g., checking), or 'attraction' (as proposed in De Clercq (2020)). This is depicted in the simplified structure in (39) with the trace t_{ne}.

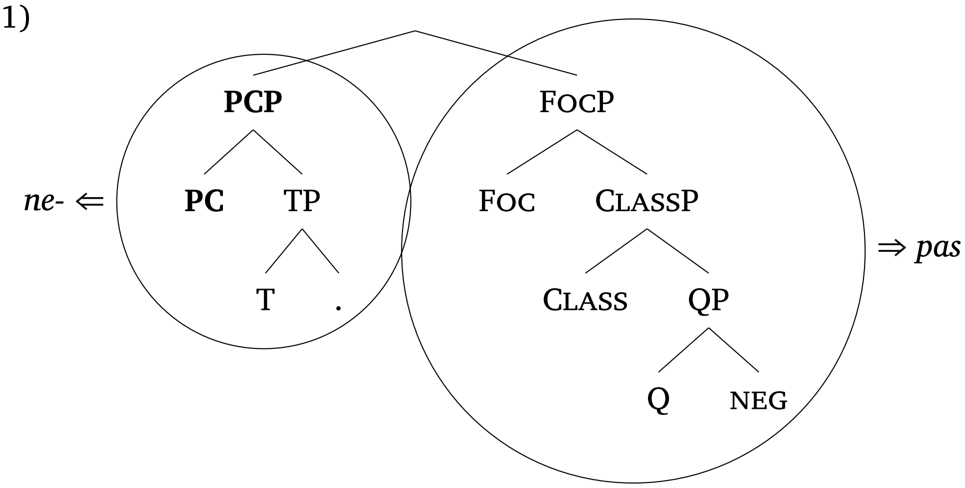
(39)



With possibility conditionals, as the one in (40), syntax simply merges an additional feature, PC, with the existing structure, and searches a matching lexical item for it. Since *ne* also comprises this feature, it can keep lexicalising it, (41).[18] Note that unless specified otherwise, all the trees discussed from this point onwards are 'hybrid', i.e., we only represent the lexical items and how they would be lexicalised within each context.

(40) (French)
Si tu **ne** souffres **pas**, tu n'apprends pas.
if you NEG suffer.PRS.2SG NEG you NEG-learn.PRS.2SG NEG
'If you don't suffer, you don't learn.'

(41)



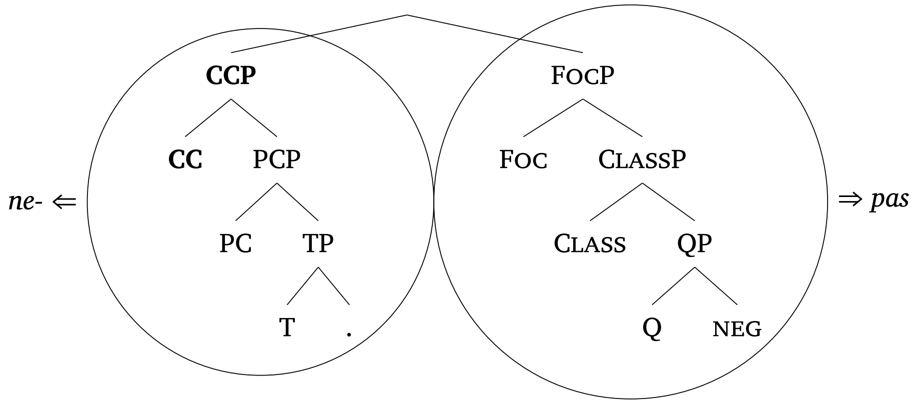
With counterfactual conditionals, as the one in (42), we expect the same to happen: the left branch is expanded once more, this time by the addition of the feature, CC. This feature can again be lexicalised by *ne*, as shown in (43).

(42) (French)
Si tu **n'** avais **pas** gaspillé l' argent,
if you NEG have.PST.IPFV.2SG NEG waste.PST.PTCP the money
tu aurais construit une maison.
you have.COND.2SG build.PST.PTCP a house

[18]While it is not yet fully crystallised where new features should be merged when there are multiple derivations, the current consensus is that syntax operates in a kind of trickle-down fashion. This means it first attempts to find a match in the main spine and, if unsuccessful, remerges the feature in the closest available workspace, the ne CLB in this case. It repeats this process as many times as is needed to lexicalise the feature, (cf. Starke (2024)).

‘If you hadn’t wasted the money, you would’ve built a house.’

(43)



As we move through volitionals as in (44) and prohibitives as in (45), the same process is repeated. For each modal layer that is merged, syntax adds a new, corresponding feature. And since each of those features is contained within the lexical item of *ne*, there is always a match.

(44) (French)

Je veux que Marie **ne** parte **pas**.
I want that Marie NEG leave.SBJV.PRS.3SG NEG

‘I want Marie not to leave.’

(45) **Ne** mange **pas**!
NEG eat.IMP.2SG NEG

‘Don’t eat!’

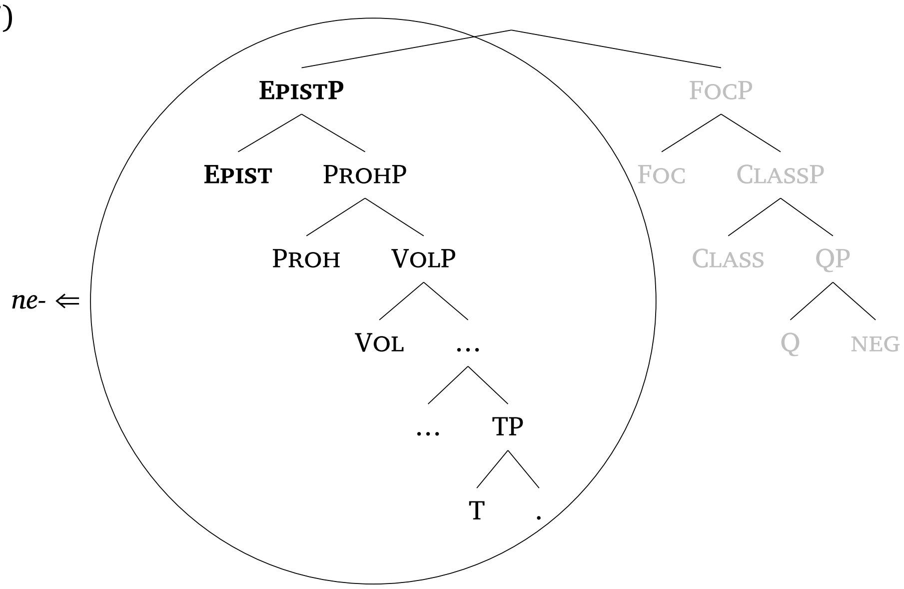
In order to realise ExN under *fear*-predicates, such as the one in (46), syntax must merge an additional feature, EPIST. Crucially, however, only the left branch matters in these contexts. As the absence of *pas* reveals, the main NEG spine is neither merged nor lexicalised, as indicated by the greyed-out FSEQ in (47). With the absence of this portion of the spine, there is also no negative meaning.

(46) (French)

Je crains que Marie ne vienne.
I fear that Marie NEG come.SBJV.PRS.3SG

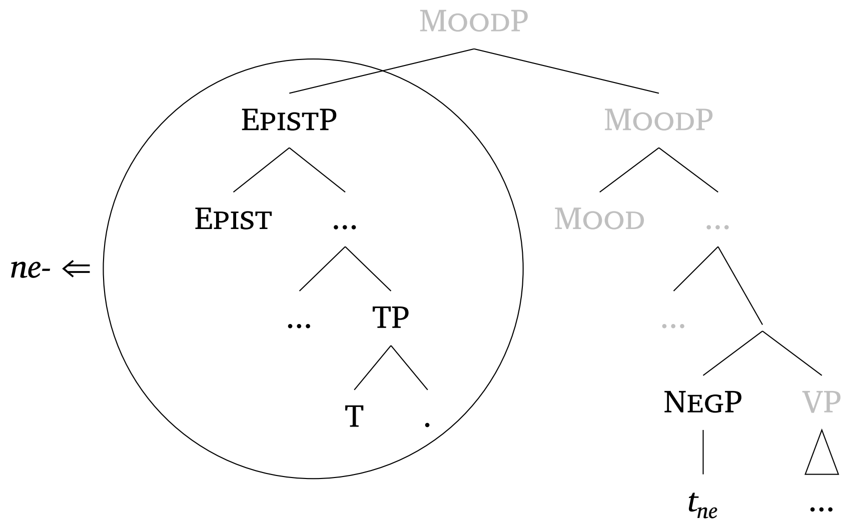
‘I fear that Marie will come.’

(47)



Within the bigger picture, this could look like (48).[19]

(48)



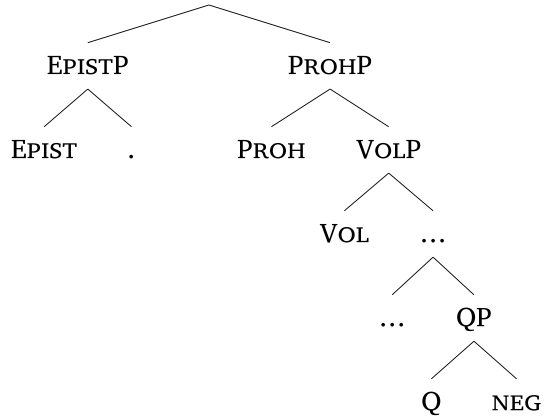
While French requires two separate lexical items to realise the complex structure, the prediction or at least the expectation, is that there are also languages with lexical items big enough to contain it as whole.[20]

[19]Note that the tree in (48) shows one of the syntactic options, where *ne* is base-generated inside a NegP and moves to TP together with the verb, as is commonly assumed in the syntactic tradition (cf. Pollock 1989). However, it is also possible that ExN is merged *in situ* above Mood. Pending additional empirical support in favour of either one of the options, we remain agnostic about which derivation should be preferred.

[20]Another prediction following from the structure we propose is that there should be negative epistemic markers, where the full structure is not only contained within

And there are. Czech, and by extension all the Pattern 1 languages that exhibit a full syncretism fit the description. In these languages, the two branches are not lexicalised by individual lexical items but are instead contained within that of a single morpheme, as shown in (49).

(49) */ne-/* ⇔

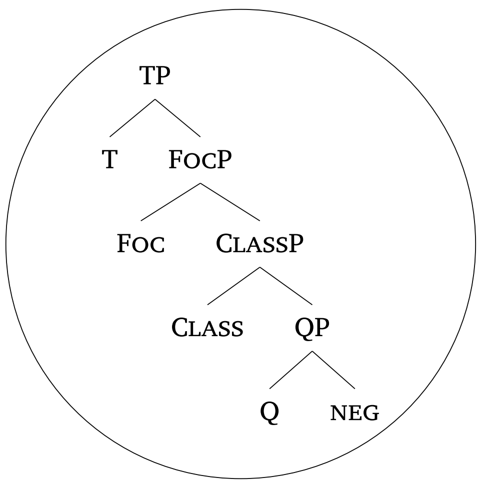


This means that the Czech prefix *ne-* can lexicalise the structure for tensed predicates, as in (50), because the right branch has a matching subconstituent, (51).

(50) (Czech)

Petr **ne**-přišel na oslavu.
Peter NEG-come.PAST to party
'Peter didn't come to the party.'

(51)



⇒ *ne-*

the lexical item, but also realised as such. As of yet, we have not seriously investigated the existence of such markers, but we are hopeful to come back to this issue.

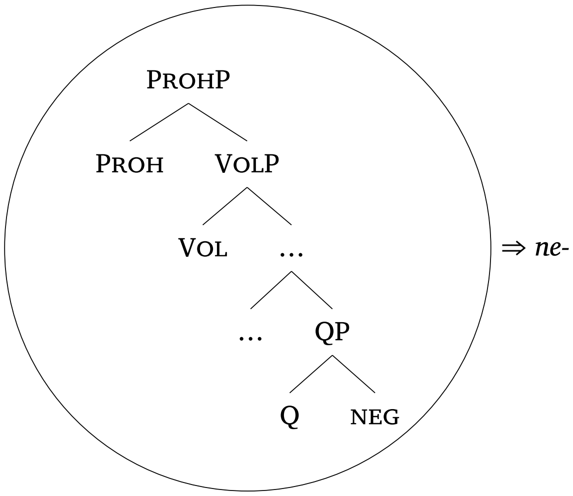
But it can also realise the structure all the way up to prohibitive, as in (52), in which case it lexicalises the right branch fully, as shown in (55).

(52) (Czech)

Ne-choď	na	oslavu!
NEG-come.IMP.2SG	to	party

‘Don’t come to the party!’

(53)



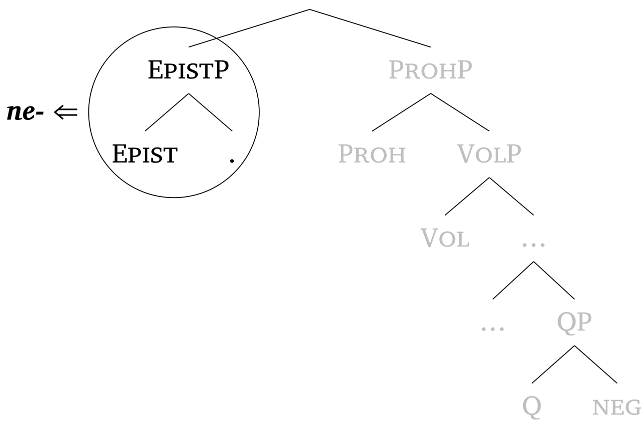
However, in the case of EXN, as in (54), *ne-* can lexicalise only the epistemic feature, effectively ‘losing’ its negative feature.

(54) (Czech)

Petr	se	bál,	aby	Karel	**ne**-přišel.
Peter	REFL	feared	that-SBJV	Karel	EXN-came.PERF

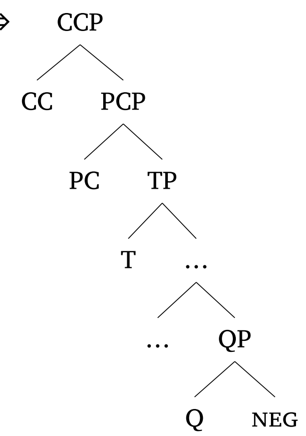
‘Peter was afraid that Karel would come.’ (Dočekal 2012)

(55)

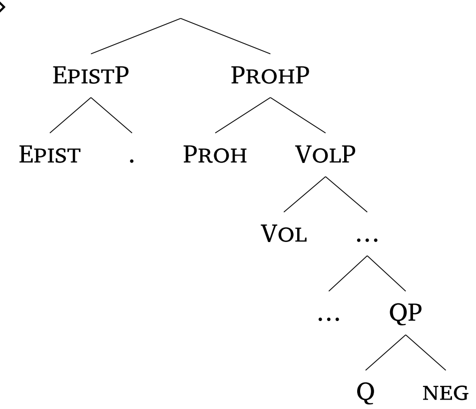


Lastly, the same logic applies in Modern Greek as in French. Recall that this language also uses two distinct negative markers, *dhen* and *min*. What is different is the distribution of the FSEQ features across the lexical items. That is, *dhen* does not only function as the standard negator, but also appears in possibility and counterfactual conditionals. Accordingly, its lexical item takes the shape in (56a). *Min*, on the other hand, is the marker of volitive and prohibitive negation, and ExN under *fear*-predicates. Its lexical item resembles that of Czech *ne*, (56b), to be able to override the smaller one.

(56) a. */dhen/* ⟺



b. */min/* ⟺



In practice, in possibility and counterfactual conditionals as (57)–(58), *dhen* is capable of lexicalising the structure shown in (59), because its lexical structure constitutes a perfect match.

(57) (Modern Greek, Chatzopoulou & Sitaridou 2014)

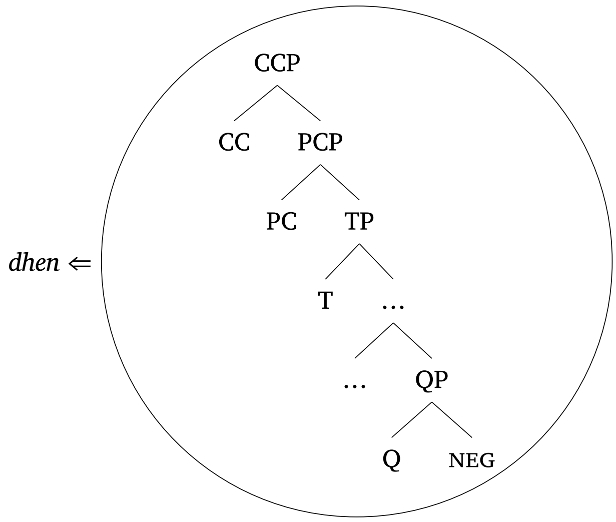
An **dhen** pathis, dhen tha mathis.
if NEG suffer.SBJV.2SG NEG FUT learn.SBJV.2SG
'If you don't suffer, you will not learn.'

(58) (Modern Greek, Chatzopoulou & Sitaridou 2014)

An **dhen** ixa xasi ta lefta, tha
if NEG have.PST.1SG lose.PST.PTCP the money FUT
extiza spiti.
build.PST.1SG house

‘If I had not lost the money, I would have built a house.’

(59)



At the point where VOL and PROH are introduced, (60)-(61), *min* will override *dhen* as now there is a perfect match with this lexical item instead.

(60) (Chatzopoulou & Sitaridou 2014)

Esi thelis ego na min troo.
you.NOM want.2SG I.NOM SUBJ NEG eat.1SG

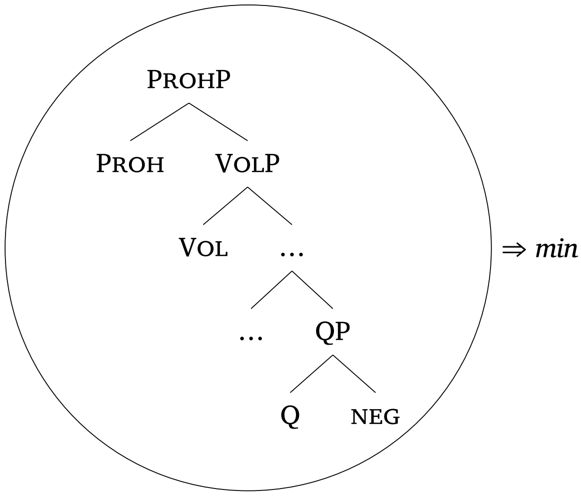
‘You don’t want me to eat.’

(61) (Modern Greek, Baunaz & Lander 2023)

Min/*dhen eísai vlákas!
NEG2/NEG1 be.2SG stupid

‘Don’t be stupid!’

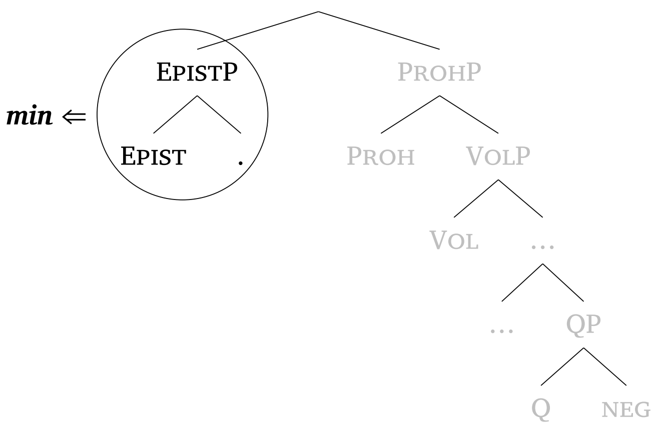
(62)



But as we have seen, its lexical item is complex and it can also realise the subconstituent on the right branch if it embedded under a *fear*-predicate, as in (63)-(64).

(63) (Modern Greek, Makri 2013)
Fovame min espasa to podhi mu.
fear.1SG NEG break.1SG the leg mine.CL
'I am afraid that I might have broken my leg.'

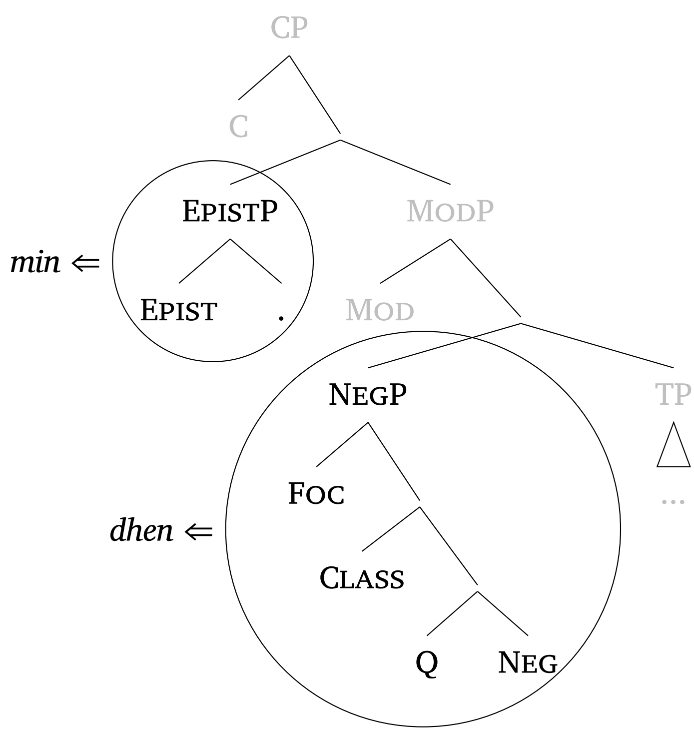
(64)



Note that this kind of lexicalisation also allows us to easily capture the previously mentioned stacking of *min* on top of *dhen*, (65).

(65) Fovame **min** **dhen** efaye tipota o babas
I.fear NEG2 NEG1 ate nothing the dad
'I fear dad maybe didn't eat anything.'

(66)



We have now analysed all three patterns of syncretism in French, Modern Greek, and Czech. The central takeaway is that while the distribution of features in the lexical items varies from language to language, what remains constant is the underlying functional sequence (FSEQ) and the function of ExN in this FSEQ as a non-negative, epistemic modal. This approach is also economical in the sense that it requires no additional theoretical assumptions beyond the one that variation is lexical (cf. the *Borer-Chomsky conjecture*, section 1). In addition, we do not need to posit any extra expletive elements, nor must we rely on extra syntactic movements to distinguish the function of one form from another. The observed variation falls out naturally from the interaction between a fixed syntactic hierarchy and language-specific lexicalisation patterns.

6 Conclusion

In this paper, we examined three patterns of syncretism that arise cross-linguistically between instances of real negation (NEG) and so-called 'expletive' negation (ExN) and argued that this recurrent morphological overlap reflects underlying structural proximity in the negative functional sequence. More specifically, we argued that ExN in the context of *fear*-predicates is the exponent of a high modal projection immediately adjacent to the layers identified for modal negation. This is consistent with its semantic profile and previous accounts by Makri (2013) and Tsiakmakis & Espinal (2022) for Modern Greek. Following this, we proposed a Nanosyntactic analysis which not only allowed us to capture the shared morphological realisation of ExN and NEG, but also enabled us to explain the cross-linguistic variation in the attested patterns through simple, but fine-grained distinctions in the lexical specifications of these markers in each language. As such, we offered a unified, formal analysis that derives the surface distribution of ExN from independently motivated, structural and interpretive principles. The resulting picture supports a view of morphosyntactic structure in which apparent surface mismatches, such as those involving ExN, arise naturally from and may be reduced to the interaction between universal functional hierarchies and language-specific lexicalisation strategies.

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